

Housing Revenue Account (HRA) 2026-27

Rent Setting

Resident Engagement

Response to proposals in the fees and charges changes reviewed by Cabinet on 2 December 2025

Contents

How we engaged.....3

Publicity of meetings.....3

Themes.....4

Proposals.....5

Local Housing Forums.....5

 South5

 Central East 6

 North East.....6

 North West.....8

 Central West.....8

 Tenant Forum.....9

 Online event.....10

 Equalities Monitoring.....16

How We Engaged

Engagement with residents occurred via:

- An online boroughwide meeting via MS Teams on 10 December 2025 for all residents
- 5 Local Housing Forum meetings between 11 and 17 December 2025 – one online (South) and the other 4 in person in their usual locations across the borough.
- Tenant Forum meeting on 18 December 2025 at Tooley Street.

Publicity of Meetings

- The 7 meetings were publicised by sending out emails containing all details of meetings to be held along with links to the Eventbrite page, MS Teams links for the online boroughwide meeting, and for the South Local Housing Forum meeting.
- Meeting details were sent via emails to all council tenants and homeowners for whom a valid email address was held - circa 30,000 residents - by govdelivery. The open rate for the emails was around 52% (14,711). 250 people clicked on links within the mailout.
- Consultation event details were also included in the December Housing e-newsletter which has a circulation of around 30,000 residents.
- Resident Involvement Officers also promoted the events by sending invitations via their respective Local Housing Forum chairs and TRA membership.
- Contact details of the Resident Involvement team were included for further information and queries.
- The Eventbrite platform allowed residents to register their interest in attending the online meeting and for information to be sent out directly to them in advance of the meeting.
- Residents who registered for the online event via Eventbrite received:
 - HRA Cabinet Report by Ian Young, Assistant Director of Finance (Housing)
 - Link and QR code to the MS Forms questionnaire highlighting the proposals and the areas for resident's feedback
 - The HRA rent PowerPoint presentation from Ian Young
 - The MS Teams link for the main online event on 10 December 2025.
- The same documents were posted in the chat room of the online meetings and copies of all documents were either sent out via email ahead of the event or hard copies brought to the in-person meetings at Local Housing Forums and Tenant Forum meetings.

Themes

Across the 7 events, several themes emerged from the questions and comments of those who attended in person and online about why they agreed or disagreed with the proposed changes to rent and other tenant charges.

The themes for those who **did not agree** with the proposed changes to charges mentioned:

Reason given	Respondents
Lack of affordability	29
Cost of Living expensive	13
4.8% exceeds inflation	5
Poor service delivery	14
Low value for money	4
Poor stock conditions	5
Other	3

The majority of people who responded opposed the increase to rent and charges.

58% (42 residents) of those who did not agree with the 4.8% rent increase cited a lack of affordability and potentially struggling to pay the extra amount faced with cost-of-living increases, low or static income, financial stress and rent arrears, amongst other things.

32% (23 residents) of those who did not agree with the rent increase mentioned poor or falling service levels and delivery, little value for money and high wastage on council repairs contracts on specific items such as scaffolding, multiple repairs of the same items and compensation paid out as a result, and housing stock that was ageing and in poor condition in some parts of the borough with disrepair, damp and mould, pest infestations, etc.

7% (5 residents) highlighted that the increase was unfair because it was above the rate of inflation.

Homeowners, although not eligible to vote on all proposals, were mostly opposed to any increases in rent and service charges.

Respondents unanimously agreed to freezing heating network charges for the coming financial year.

Rent Setting Proposals

The HRA report set out six proposals regarding rent and service charges for the coming financial year. Residents were asked to identify whether they were tenants or leaseholders to facilitate voting on the questions relevant to their tenure. Tenants were asked to vote on all six proposals, leaseholders voted on the two proposals relating to garages and district heating only. Voters were asked whether they agreed or disagreed with the proposals and why.

Local Housing forums

Rent consultation was conducted at all 5 Local Housing Forums and at Tenant Forum.

South Forum - 11 December 2025

26 Residents attended and were asked to vote using the QR code or link to the questionnaire that was posted in the meeting chat. Their responses are included in the online results above. In the room, residents opposed the rent and charges increases.

Issues raised at meeting:

- People are concerned about affordability and believe people will genuinely struggle to meet this additional cost
- They were concerned that the rent increase will lead to more arrears, failure to collect income and more evictions at great consequence for individual households. Hearing about increases but nothing about improving services, lighting, dirty blocks. We are not getting value for money and services are poor. Is there a plan for improving services?
- How good is the data on your properties as the average rents don't seem to reflect real rents being paid by tenants present at the meeting
- Properties differ across the borough. Some blocks in the same area have better services and facilities like lifts and the rent is the same and there are lots of issues like ASB. Don't mind paying more but want value for money.

- Scaffolding being up for excessive amounts of time and contractors not doing the work they are paid to do. Residents felt that the cost is passed onto residents. Better checks on contractors are needed.

Central East Forum – 15 December 2025

A special meeting was convened to discuss rent setting as the sole item on the agenda. 7 residents attended. Following the presentation, there was discussion and questions regarding how the rent was set, what target rent was and how it was calculated. 4 residents – 2 tenants and 2 leaseholders - completed the questionnaire at the meeting with 3 others agreeing to complete online. The data from the completed questionnaires is included in the section on the questionnaire results.

Residents at the meeting in the main did not agree with the proposed increases in rents and charges.

The discussions focussed on lack of affordability, poor service delivery and little value for money.

Residents felt that garages vary across the borough and that charges could not be universal as they offered different services such as water to renters, whereas other garages did not have access to a water supply. One resident queried why they were charged for heating all year round when it was turned off during the warmer months.

Residents wanted a better breakdown of charges so they could better understand what they were being charged for.

North East Forum 15 December 2025

The approach taken at this meeting was to discuss each proposal and vote as a group on each proposal. 16 residents attended, 4 were leaseholders and ineligible to vote on 6 of the 8 questions

The response:

Residents reluctantly agreed with the proposed rent increase of 4.8% providing that services flagged by the forum for action are significantly improved and that the council continues to provide advice and support to residents struggling to pay the rent and charges.

However, the meeting also raised the concerns about residents on low incomes but who did not qualify for benefits. Recommended that the council continues to support residents access advice services such as Citizen Advice Southwark, and cost of living initiatives and providing more support where possible

Residents reluctantly agreed with the proposed increase to tenant service charges.

However, there was considerable concern raised about the quality of service received across all parts of the suite of service-related charges. There was a call for:

- reintroduction of fixed penalty notices for infringements such as urinating in lifts,
- resolution of some blocks being outside the cleaning contracts specifications yet still paying for service.
- Improvements to the quality of door entry systems to improve security and safety of residents.

People commented on how the Council wastes money, identifying communal lighting and lack of control over when lighting came on as an example

No vote was taken at this meeting regarding rent convergence.

However, there was discussion about the issue. In principle people were supportive of rent increase to enable the HRA to invest in its homes and services, however wanted this rise to be linked to real improvements and investment in housing. Members referred to the previous convergence being linked to Warm Dry Safe programme and delivering decent homes.

Residents abstained from voting on the proposed increase in garage charges but raised concerns about how garages were used and the potential fire risks.

No vote was taken regarding the freezing of the heat network charges. However, people expressed concern about the cost of the networks, and highlighted the following:

- No lagging on the pipes contributing to considerable waste
- No planned maintenance
- Not optimising the use of the network.
- Breakdowns and lack of reliability

The chair of this forum sent a subsequent email to the Head of Resident Engagement regarding voting and the issues raised at the forum meeting (see below)

North West Forum 17 December 2025

15 residents attended the meeting. They voted collectively and unanimously rejected the proposed rent increases. They highlighted that for the past 4 years the rents systematically increased while the repairs services have decreased are so bad that rent increases were not justified as LBS had not delivered value for money for years while increasing costs.

No votes were taken regarding garages and heat network charges, however the same value for money comments were made.

Other issues raised in discussion:

- Rents should be means tested
- Service delivery reported as a failure a lady went in tears as her elderly neighbour was left for months without heating while rents were enforced in full with no contact from Resident Services Manager and no one to help – missed appointments, etc almost everyone around the table shared various experiences as poor service delivery and LBS totally irresponsible when reported
- Residents requested explanation and feedback on debt financing of £42.3m and a breakdown of:
 - the total value of current debt
 - the breakdown of the debt on types of reasons to raise the various rounds of debt
 - the % and amount on each of the types of debt mentioned above
- For capital financing, question were raised around why different types of financing draws different levels of interest

Central West Forum 17 December 2025

10 residents attended this forum meeting. Following the presentation, paper questionnaires were completed and collected from 5 residents – 3 tenants and 2 leaseholders. Others in attendance opted to complete their questionnaires online via the link and QR code and the feedback is included in the online section above.

Residents **unanimously opposed** the proposed rent increase of 4.8%.

Discussions focussed on:

- Lack of affordability
- Poor service delivery

- Cost of living increases
- Lack of value for money
- Conditions of some housing did not warrant a rent increase

Residents unanimously opposed increases to any of the other charges and the application of rent convergence to tenant's rents. However, they agreed with freezing heat network charges.

Other issues raised:

- lack of time for consultation on rent setting
- why consultation done during pending festive season
- residents felt that the decision was already made to increase rent
- what would be done to assist those who could not afford the increase
- Southwark Council need to look at how they are spending money and seek to properly monitor their contracts to ensure value for money.

Tenant Forum 18 December 2025

This meeting was convened to discuss rent setting and to hear feedback on rent setting from recent the Local Housing forum meetings. Panel members heard the presentation from Timothy Jones, Director of Corporate Finance, followed by a Q&A session. Jessica Leech, Head of Resident Engagement, presented feedback from the 5 local housing forum meetings. However, at point of voting on the proposals, 3 forum members left the meeting which became inquorate so no final vote could be taken.

Discussion and questions included:

- At what stage efficiencies would factor into the debt financing figures, as that figure is continually rising
- The high cost of using Plentific and whether savings could be made
- Concerns regarding value for money in relation to poor services
- Timing of rent consultation. Residents felt there was not enough time to have proper consultation and give them a chance to prepare. Plus, right in the middle of the festive season.
- The application of rent convergence

Online Meeting

Via MS Teams – 10 December 2025

Prior to the meeting, 62 residents had registered via Eventbrite and were sent documents and meeting link details.

15 of those residents who registered joined the MS Teams meeting.

Residents were welcomed by the Chair and were given an introduction and overview by Abi Oguntogun, Director of Landlord Services followed by a presentation – Better Homes & Better Repairs – Delivering the Good Landlord Plan by Ryan Collymore, Director of Repairs and Maintenance. Timothy Jones, Director of Corporate Finance delivered a presentation outlining the proposed HRA rent and charges for 2026/27.

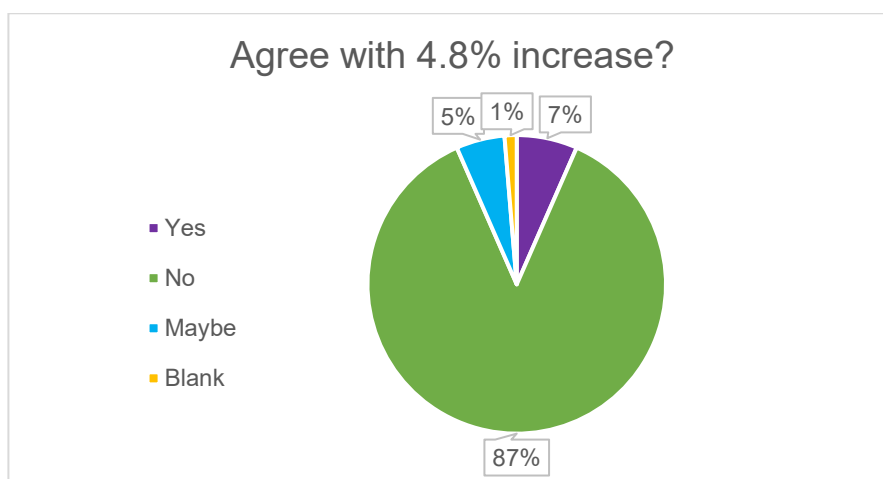
A Q&A session followed, where residents raised questions regarding rent charges by posting in the meeting chat. Questions about Ryan's presentation, Landlord services, personal concerns relating to individual properties and not relating to rent setting were funnelled through the resident involvement inbox resident.participation@southwark.gov.uk for subsequent response by the relevant service team.

Breakout room polling via MS Teams presented technical difficulties for some residents. Consequently, the MS Forms questionnaire link and QR code were posted in the meeting chat for residents to complete during or after the meeting. Those who had registered but did not attend were contacted by email following the meeting and invited to complete the questionnaire.

Online Responses to HRA rent and charges proposals

97 residents responded online – 76 (78%) tenants and 21 (22%) leaseholders. 61% of those who live in our buildings are tenants. Those who signed up to the 2 online events from the Local Housing Forums who responded individually have been added to the online responses. Tenants were asked to respond to all the 6 proposals, while Homeowners only responded to the proposals about garage charges and district heating.

Tenants were asked whether they agreed with the proposed rent increase of 4.8% for all tenants, including TMO and Shared Ownership. Of the 76 tenants who responded to the question, 87% (66 residents) said 'No' they did not agree. 7% (5 residents) said 'Yes' they agreed with the 4.8% proposed increase and 5% (4 residents) responded 'Maybe' and were undecided.



Residents were asked to summarise why they answered in the way they did. 7% (5 residents) of those who responded agreed with the rent increase and a further 5% (4 residents) were undecided. Their responses can be summarised and grouped as follows:

Some reasons given for **agreeing with rent increase**:

- Tenants should contribute to the additional expenses
- Increases although unwanted are necessary due to the rising cost of everything.
- Happy for an overall increase. And is somewhat expected with current levels of inflation, etc
- I think it's fair and they are building more houses
- Any rent rise is unwelcome however, as a tenant I need to be realistic with what the annual increase might be and 4.8 seems ok
- Rent increases for tenants have been relatively modest in recent years, particularly when compared with private renters. Council tenants already benefit from substantially lower-than-market rents and the security of tenancy. It is therefore fair and reasonable that they contribute slightly more. The proposed adjustment would strengthen the Council's financial position, enabling it to expand the supply of new affordable homes — whether through acquisition or direct delivery — for those in need.

- It should be much higher! people complaining about paying £800 to live in a 3-bed flat. Check the market rate and thank the taxpayer.

Some reasons given by the 87% (66 residents) who **disagreed with rent increase**:

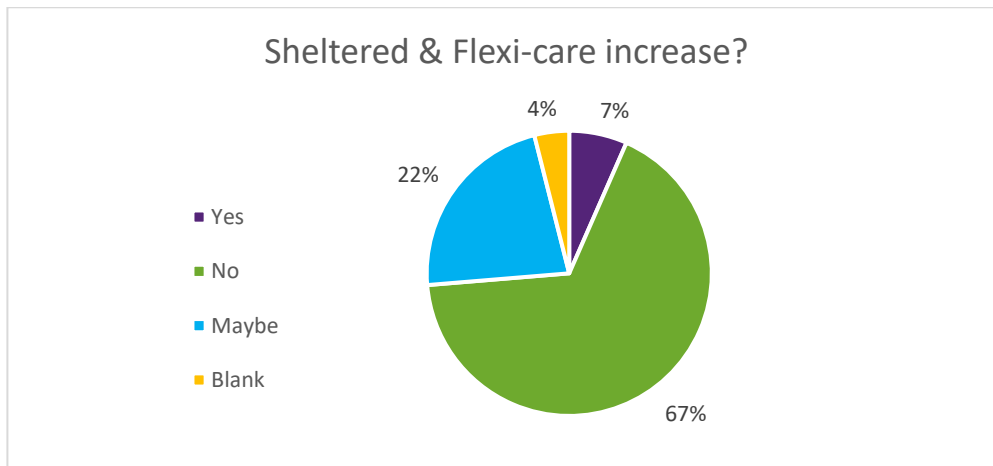


Fig. 1. Word cloud of responses.

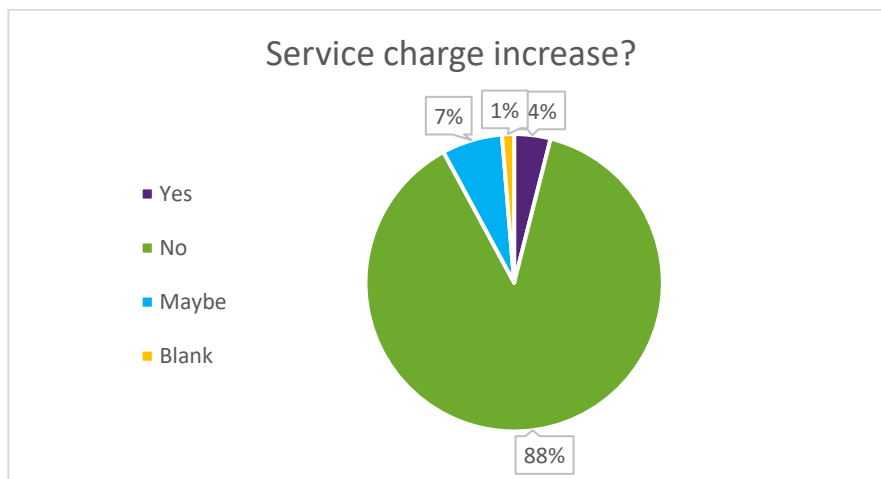
- Lack of affordability due to cost-of-living increases, inflation, etc
- Perceived poor service delivery not matching proposed increase or presenting value for money
- The increasing costs of social housing and inability of residents to pay.
- Poor housing conditions and disrepair
- Salaries not increasing but living costs continually rising
- Proposed rent increase above rate of inflation.
- The disparity of living conditions between those living in older homes and those in newer, more energy efficient homes

87% of tenants who responded did not agree with any increases in rent or service charges:

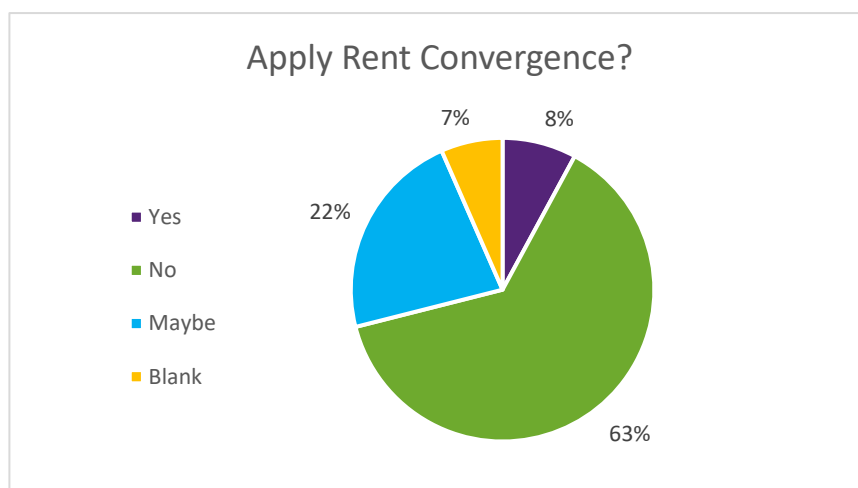
67% of tenants who responded did not agree with increases to sheltered and flexi-care housing service charges



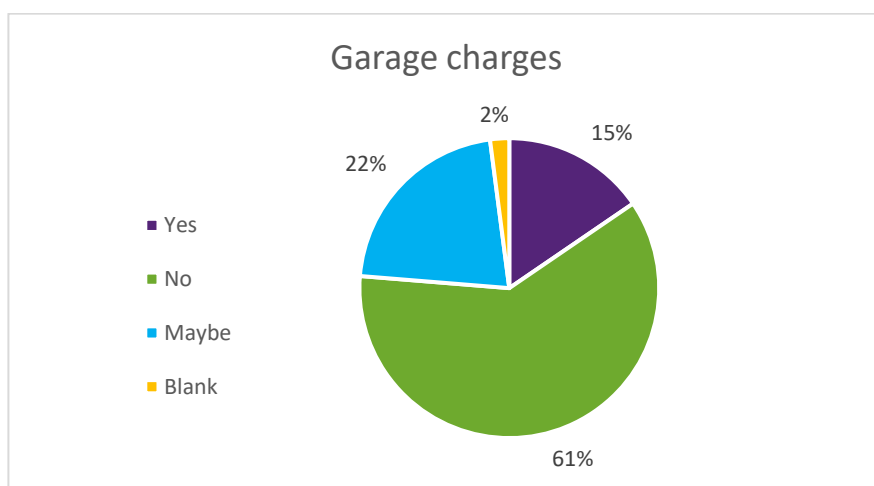
88% of tenants who responded did not agree with the increase to tenant service charges.



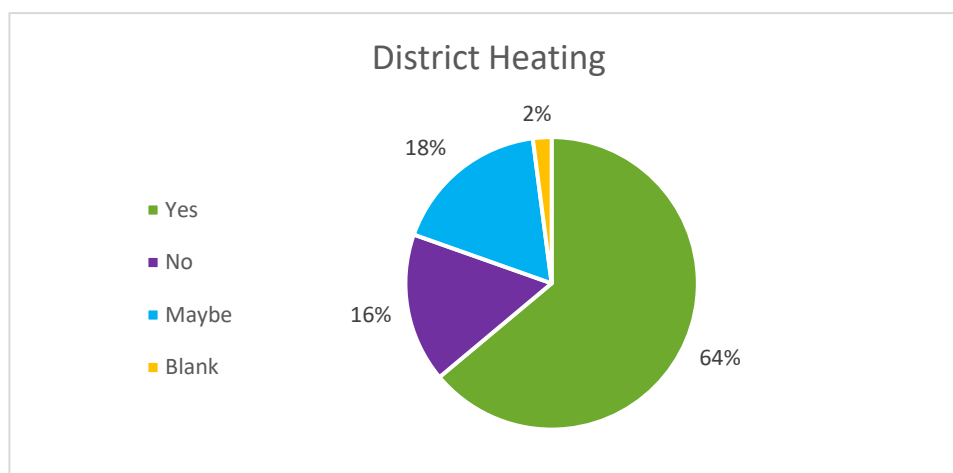
63% of tenants who respondents did not want rent convergence added to existing tenants' rents. Rent convergence had to be explained to residents.



All 97 respondents (76 tenants and 21 homeowners) could vote on garage and district heating charges. 63% of those who voted **did not agree** with increasing garage charges.



65% of respondents agreed with freezing heat network charges for 2026/27 at existing levels from 6 April 2026:



Other comments:

- Scrapping the disability part of the cost of renting a garage is not a good thought-out move. It will affect a lot of people who do not own their own cars and utilise the garage for storage purposes.
- We need to feel satisfaction we are getting value for money which we are not more increase is not fair or sustainable
- Estate buildings are not very clean most of the times as cleaners rarely turns up on the days due.
- Please do a better job at explaining target rent. I am still so confused but otherwise I do see Southwark as a good borough that is trying to make a difference.
- I would also like to highlight the importance of improving communication and transparency with tenants. Clear explanations about how rent and service charges are calculated would help residents understand the decisions being made.
- Increases in any charges to families should be an exception only and not across the board just because the statistical retail price index went up. If unavoidable specific costs and expenses to the specific building justify an increase then it is acceptable, otherwise not at all.
- I do not agree with rent convergence to existing tenants as this would imply that existing residents would be living in the same quality of those newly built properties which just isn't the case. Until all homes are brought to that standard the convergence should not apply.

- Increasing charges doesn't lead to better services they get worse. Councils always raise revenue by increasing everything maybe they should look where they could save money and stop just doing the minimum to implement a sticking plaster.

Equalities Monitoring

Residents completing the rent consultation survey online were also asked to provide demographic information. The data below was provided by the 97 residents who completed the survey online.

4 respondents (4%) opted not to provide any demographic information, but gave their views on the proposals

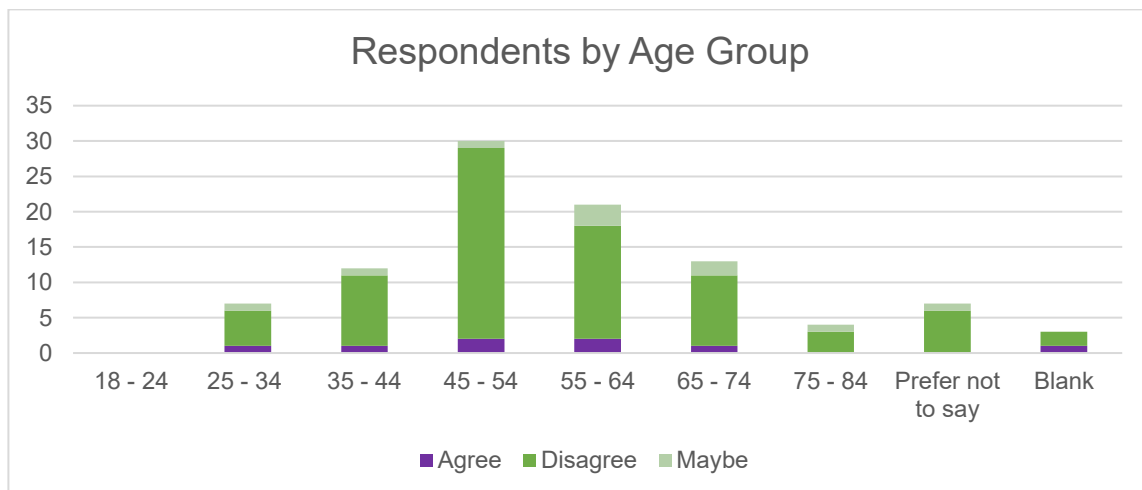
Gender

- Of the 76 tenants who responded, 44 (58%) were female and 25 (33%) were male, with the remaining 7 (9%) respondents either declining to provide their gender
- 88% of respondents disagreed with the 4.8% increase in council rents. 51% of female and 28% male respondents did not agree with the proposed rent increase.
- 7 respondents (9%) either preferred not to say or did not identify as having the same gender assigned at birth.

Gender	Agree	Disagree	Maybe	Total
Female	3	39	2	44
Male	2	21	2	25
Other		1		1
Prefer not to say		4		4
Blank		2		2
Total	5	67	4	76

Age

Age Group	Agree	Disagree	Maybe	Total
25 - 34	1	5	1	7
35 - 44	1	10	1	12
45 - 54	2	27	1	30
55 - 64	2	16	3	21
65 - 74	1	10	2	13
75 - 84		3	1	4
Prefer not to say		6	1	7
Blank	1	2		3
Total	8	79	10	97

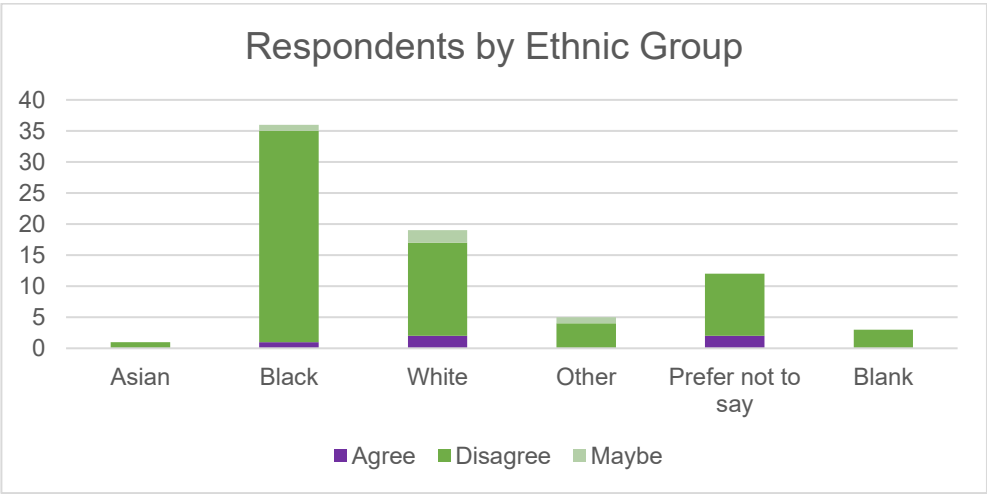


The most frequently selected age group is 45 – 54 years, which represents 31% of those who responded. Within this group 90% (27 respondents) disagreed with the Council’s proposals to increase rents.

Ethnicity

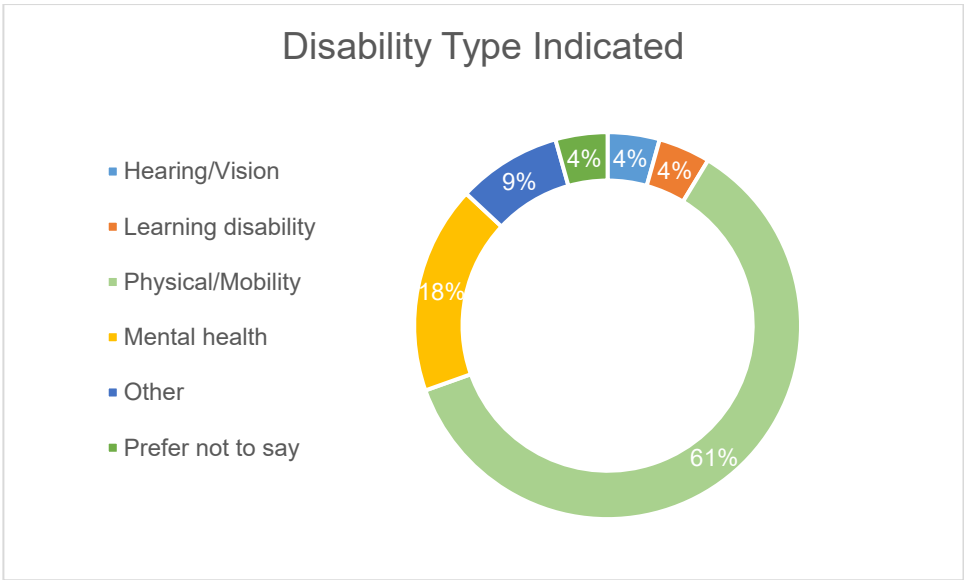
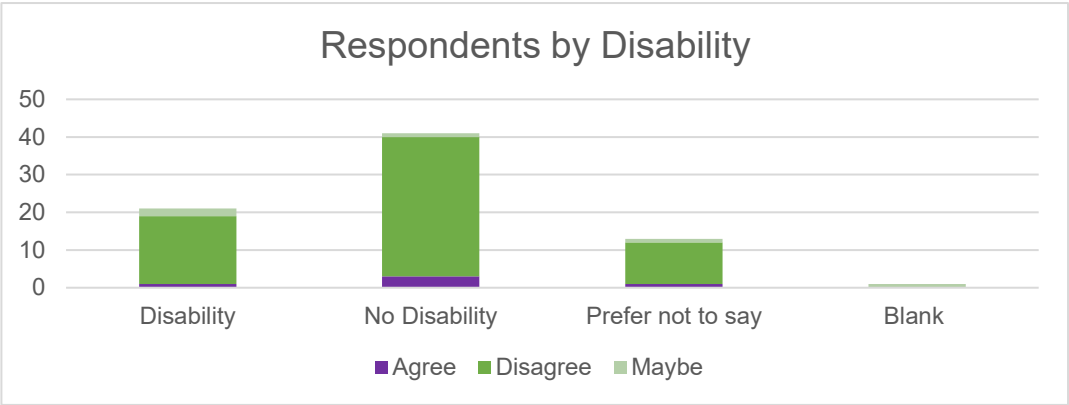
82 of the 97 respondents (85%) provided information relating to their ethnicity. 15 (16%) respondents preferred not to reveal their ethnicity and 5 (5%) respondents declined to answer the question.

76 tenants voted on the proposed rent and service charge increases. Homeowners, although not able to vote, generally disagreed with any increases in rent or charges.



Disability

97 residents responded regarding disability. 23 (24%) of all those who responded specified that they had a disability. Of the 76 tenants eligible to vote on all the proposals, 21 (28%) indicated that they had a disability and 13 (17%) preferred not to say.



Email received from Jerry Hewitt – Chair of the North East Local Housing Forum - following the rent setting meeting on 15 December 2025:

Dear Verna,
Please see below comments from the North East Local Housing Forum.
Regards,
Jerry Hewitt
Vice Chair NELHF

North East Local Housing Forum comments

Tenants Service Charges

Rent increase:

The forum **reluctantly** agrees the 4.8% increase provided that services our forum has flagged up for action are improved and put right, including the promises and commitments that Southwark has failed to deliver, and the council continues to provide advice and support to residents struggling to pay the rent and charges. The forum notes that Southwark council housing is now in a dire state and the forum has no confidence in Housing Department / Landlord Service director level (including acting) management responsible. Very large payments are made by the HRA to other council departments that need to be properly, thoroughly, urgently and transparently reviewed to ensure value for money. Residents are extremely concerned that Plentific will fail to deliver value for money (which includes quality) and repairs provided using this so-called “marketplace” will increase costs for the council and tenants (incl. time and hassle, lower quality). The annual rent increase now costs many residents one or two weeks income forcing many more residents to claim help from the DWP with no guarantee future Governments will continue to pay and there are threats of benefit reductions. Staff are entitled to their pay increases, holidays, sick leave, pension and fair working conditions etc which require rent increases to maintain or severe cuts in services that will only make housing services even worse. RSO’s for every estate / patch are still not sorted out with valued staff continuing to leave. RSO patch sizes were increased without addressing the multiple issues that needed to be sorted out to address RSO workload and responsibilities. The excessive repairs backlog continues with some repairs ongoing for years eg leaking gutters high rise blocks and window / window frame repairs (incl. Major Works defects). Lifts must be maintained properly and not cause noise nuisance to residents thumping / scraping up and down lift shafts in high rise blocks.

Estate Cleaning:

The forum **reluctantly** agrees the 54p a week increase however Housing Management have repeatedly failed to ensure all blocks are kept reasonably clean which is unfair and an injustice for tenants paying the pooled charge. External balcony walkways were removed from the cleaning contract / SLA bar the flooring. Cleaning staff must be properly provided with the support, materials and equipment for the council to meet its tenancy agreement obligations. The service has delivered less every year (stealth cuts) while charging more money and Housing Management failed to negotiate with the cleaning service to secure a reasonable agreement for all blocks and every property required to pay a charge. The council has failed repeatedly to

“improve procurement and contract management to maximise value for money” when the council contracts with itself to supply the HRA. Consultation with tenants about the cleaning service / SLA is totally inadequate.

Grounds Maintenance:

The forum **reluctantly** agrees the 25p a week increase for grounds maintenance provided that the council stops wasting considerable time and money manually removing weeds because staff were not provided mechanical and other equipment when the council decided to stop all weed spraying leaving estates literally covered in weeds.

Communal Lighting:

The forum **reluctantly** agrees the 22p a week increase for communal lighting provided that the council stops wasting considerable energy leaving lights on in blocks 24/7/365 because systems never worked properly following Major Works etc. Communal lighting on some estates and for some blocks is also inadequate. There is considerable variation in lux levels provided comparing blocks. Resident representatives are also fed up having to report communal lights for repair because years ago Southwark cut the staff who check the lights. Blocks had hundreds of solar panels installed on roofs with the promise of estate communal lighting bills being reduced however the reductions never happened and the nobody knows if electricity is being produced or who benefits.

Door Entry:

The forum **reluctantly** agrees the 4p a week increase for Door Entry because the quality of the service is poor. Door Entry repairs take far too long and repairs carried out are poor quality.

Sheltered Housing:

The forum did not have any residents living in Sheltered Housing present at our meeting and recommends the council consults with Sheltered Housing properties. Tenants living in Sheltered Housing are best placed to provide comments about Sheltered Housing. The council should take into account that pricing out a sheltered housing resident (or other elderly residents living in general needs accommodation) may create a care home cost of over £1200 per week.

Garage Charges:

The forum notes that for many council estate residents the standard rates for our estate garages are no longer affordable. The forum reluctantly agrees the increases provided that the council takes action to inspect garages and remove items and materials that are not permitted for safety reasons. The rules are being widely flouted. Business for profit are being run using garages and businesses are also renting estate parking spaces leaving residents on opaque waiting lists. There are regularly accusations of "jumping" the waiting list. Garage blocks were built on estates for the use and amenity of the estate residents who have been priced out. These outcomes are unacceptable and made worse when estate / street parking is inadequate and estate parking allocation in need of urgent review.

Heat Network Charges:

The forum notes that all tenants will be paying to help keep heat network charges frozen and this is unfair and an injustice when tenants paying for independent heating systems receive no help from the council whatsoever. The forum agrees to freeze the charge provided that residents who benefit repay the money use to freeze the charge back to the HRA within 36 months. The forum noted that reportedly water from

SELCHP scheme comes out of the “hot” tap only warm which is unacceptable and a concern for legionnaires disease. Contracts for sheltered housing heating specify only 17oC which is well below recommended temperatures for elderly and vulnerable residents and the council repeatedly ignores this issue while residents pay again to top up their heating.

Resent Setting Consultation Questionnaire provided by the council

The forum is not keen to answer leading questions in a poorly designed questionnaire which can be taken as biased and political.

Do you agree with the proposed rent increase of 4.8% for all tenants (incl. TMO, Shared ownership; The forum is not prepared to give a “yes”, “no” or “maybe” answer to this leading question. Please see relevant comment provided above.

The proposed increase in sheltered and flexi-care housing service charges; The forum is not prepared to give a “yes”, “no” or “maybe” answer to this leading question. Please see relevant comment provided above.

The proposed increases to tenant service charges; The forum is not prepared to give a “yes”, “no” or “maybe” answer to this leading question. Please see relevant comment provided above.

Applying rent convergence to existing tenants; The forum does not agree applying rent convergence to existing tenants, we disagree and object to leading questions used for political window dressing / spin. Bringing all existing homes up to a “decent homes plus” standard (and sorting other issues too) was part and parcel of rent convergence in Southwark. Instead of ensuring all existing homes were kept in proper repair and improved the council invested millions into new council homes, maxing out HRA borrowing, while leaving existing homes to fall into very serious disrepair as Major Works schemes failed, repairs backlog continues and repair quality / outcomes on site fell. Blocks across the area are left in disrepair, run down and shabby. Decoration stopped entirely many years ago. These outcomes between existing homes and the new homes are a glaring and growing injustice and the Housing Department becomes much worse over time. Southwark reports “historically low rent” ranked around 8th lowest of London authorities without making any link to condition and the standard of services residents actually endure.

The proposed increase in garage charge rates; The forum is not prepared to give a “yes”, “no” or “maybe” answer to this leading question. Please see relevant comment provided above.

Freezing of heat network charges for 2026-27 at existing levels, with the exception of the borough-wide metered charge for new homes with effect from 6 April 2026 The forum is not prepared to give a “yes”, “no” or “maybe” answer to this leading question. Please see relevant comment provided above.

Barry Duckett & Jerry Hewitt
Chair & Vice Chair NE LHF